Her father moved jobs a lot when she was young, leading to them moving house frequently too, and she can remember being aware that money was very tight from the age of four or five years old. 'Dad didn't hold down jobs for long,' she says, 'so even when money was coming in, it never felt secure. My dad was always quite generous with money – when he had it, it was for spending, whereas my mum was much more sensible. I remember when we got some money from an employment tribunal and my dad treated me to two new dresses. Even then, aged eight or nine, I can remember thinking that it would have been better to put it away for a rainy day.'

Laura's parents divorced when she was twelve, and the money worries got worse, with her mum working three jobs to make ends meet, no child maintenance payments, and having to remortgage the house. 'I started working as soon as I could, and did as many hours as I could physically manage,' she says. 'My choice of university was based on affordability and, again, I worked long hours throughout but ended up with debt. This continued into my first few years of work. I felt like I was earning a decent wage – I started on £26.5k – and so should be able to keep up with all my colleagues. At that time, I didn't realize that they were all still being funded by the bank of mum and dad in one way or another.'

This issue with comparison and keeping up with those who – whether we realize it or not – have greater financial means than us is something that comes up often in my